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Transport and social exclusion: Where are we now?

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ABSTRACT

The late 1990s and early 2000s witnessed a growing interest amongst UK academics and policy makers in the issue of transport disadvantage and, more innovatively, how this might relate to growing concerns about the social exclusion of low income groups and communities. Studies (predominantly in the United Kingdom) began to make more explicit the links policy between poverty, transport disadvantage, access to key services and economic and social exclusion (see for example Church and Frost, 2000; TRaC, 2000; Lucas et al., 2001; Kenyon 2003; Kenyon et al., 2003; Hodgson and Turner, 2003; Raje, 2003).

By 2003, the UK Social Exclusion Unit had published and its now internationally recognised report on this subject, which subsequently resulted in the development of a set of transport policy guidances to local authorities in England to deliver what is now commonly referred to as *accessibility planning* as part of their Local Transport Plans (Department for Transport, 2006). Since this time, researchers, policy makers and practitioners in several other countries became interested in adopting a social exclusion approach to transport planning, largely because of its utility in identifying the role of transport, land use planning and service delivery decisions in creating and reinforcing poverty and social disadvantage.

Eight years on from the SEU report, we can begin to reflect on the extent to which a social exclusion approach to the research of transport disadvantage has been successful in opening up new avenues of research enquiry and/or identifying new theoretical perspectives and/or methodological approaches. The paper begins by briefly revisiting the basic theories and core definitions which underpin and inform a social exclusion perspective. It then considers how these have been translated and understood in terms of transport. Secondly, it considers some of the emergent empirical research of transport-related exclusion that has attempted to measure and model the interactions between transport and mobility inequalities and relational negative social outcomes. Thirdly, it offers observations on progress in some key areas of policy and practice, with specific reference to the UK and Australia. It concludes by suggesting how further progress might be made on this issue and considers whether the social exclusion agenda is still a relevant approach for achieving this.

1. Introduction

The 2002–2003 Social Exclusion Unit (SEU) study of transport and social exclusion is widely recognised as having an important influence on this policy stance (Social Exclusion Unit, 2003). The most important contribution of the study is generally considered to be the way it has helped to identify the inter-relationships between transport disadvantage and key areas of social policy concern, such as unemployment, health inequalities, poor educational attainment and run-down neighbourhoods and estates. Since 2006, local transport authorities in the UK have been required to undertake strategic and local accessibility assessments as part of their statutory five yearly Local Transport Plans (Department for transport, 2006) and to work in partnership with other local public bodies to find solutions to the accessibility deficits these analyses identify. At the time of writing, it has been eight years since the UK Social Exclusion Unit (SEU) published its now widely acclaimed report on transport and social exclusion (Social Exclusion Unit, 2003). The intervening period has witnessed considerable academic interest in the subject not only in the UK but also in mainland Europe, Australasia, the Americas and South Africa.

I will be returning to a more detailed discussion of the contribution these studies in later sections of the paper, but when taken in aggregate they have largely helped to establish the highly context and person specific nature of the phenomenon, as well as to develop some innovative methodologies for identifying and measuring it. Despite this mounting body of research, there is still a great deal of confusion surrounding the concepts and definitions of transport-related social exclusion, how these might be successfully measured and modelled and whether the research of transport disadvantage from this perspective constitutes a useful approach for policy makers

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and practitioners. This paper considers and discusses these issues based on evidence of the available published and 'grey' literatures and my own experience of working in this field as an academic and policy advisor in various national and local contexts.

The scope of the paper is extremely limited, given the magnitude of this subject. It is intended to offer only an overview, rather than a comprehensive or complete review. It aims to make more explicit some of the fundamental underlying principles which underpin research enquiry in this area and to explore how far 'transport-related exclusion' can be accepted as a theoretical concept for describing the social consequences of transport. It then discusses some of the empirical research which has sought to identify and measure the incidences of transport-related exclusion in different local and national context. Finally, it draws on the evidence of two national case studies to assess progress in the development of policies and programmes to address the social exclusion effects of transport.

2. Understanding the concept of social exclusion

A great deal has already been written about social exclusion as a theoretical concept, mostly developed within the field of social policy research, and thus numerous definitions abound (Hills et al., 2002). There is no overarching consensual view about what precisely constitutes social exclusion, but there is wide agreement that it reaches beyond a description of poverty to provide a more multidimensional, multilayered and dynamic concept of deprivation. For example, Levitas et al. (2007) have identified social exclusion as involving:

> '… the lack or denial of resources, rights, goods and services, and the inability to participate in the normal relationships and activities, available to the majority of people in a society, whether in economic, social, cultural or political arenas. It affects both the quality of life of individuals and the equity and cohesion of society as a whole.' (Levitas et al., 2007: 9)

The particular rationale for adopting a social exclusion approach to transport disadvantage is that it helps policy makers to recognise that: (a) the problem is multi-dimensional i.e. can be located with both the circumstances of the individual who is affected and processes, institutions and structures within wider society; (b) it is relational i.e. disadvantage is seen in direct comparison to the normal relationships and activities of the rest of the population; and (c) it is dynamic in nature (i.e. it changes over time and space, as well as during the lifetime of the person who is affected). In policy terms, the concept also forces a focus not only on the experience of disadvantage but also on the associated economic and social **outcomes** of this condition.

Crucially, for the study of transport-related exclusion, it is essential to recognise that the concept of social exclusion emphasises the interactions between those causal *factors which lie with the individual,* such as age, disability, gender and race, *factors which lie with the structure of the local area*, such as a lack of available or inadequate public transport services, the failure of local services and *factors that lie with the national and/or global economy*, such as the re-structuring of the labour market, cultural influences, migration and legislative frameworks.

The concept is also useful from a transport policy perspective because it specifically relates these problems back to the *values, processes and actions of key delivery agencies*, which are seen to have systematically excluded certain individuals, groups or communities from the benefits of their policy decisions and practices. The implication of this conceptualisation, therefore, is that its *resolution primarily rests with the social agencies that are responsible for policy delivery*, rather than the individuals that are affected. However, it is also vital for policy makers to recognise that the abilities, skills, resources, capacities and past experiences of affected individuals also need to be considered in the design of policy solutions.

Furthermore, documenters of the phenomenon are less interested in the fact that there is no transport available to people per se but rather the *consequences of this in terms of their (in)ability to access key life-enhancing opportunities*, such as employment, education, health and their supporting social networks. In this way, there is a move away from the traditional systems-based approach to transport provision, towards *a more people-focused and needs-based social policy perspective*. It asks questions about equality of opportunity to access key services and equity of outcome rather than outputs and also begins to raise the issue of redistributive justice, i.e. the extent to which policy should seek to redistribute transport wealth in the interests of 'fairness' or 'justice' (see Lucas, 2004 for more on this).

3. Transport/mobilty disadvantage

Transport and/or mobility inequality is not a new theme within the transportation literature. For example, as early as 1973 Wachs and Kumagai identified physical mobility as a major contributor to social and economic inequality in the US context (Wachs and Kumagai, 1973). Similarly, in the UK, Banister and Hall (1981) asserted that transport clearly had an important role to play in determining social outcomes for different sectors of modern society in terms of both the absence of adequate transport services and the impact of the transport system on individuals and communities. There is also plenty of empirical evidence of this phenomenon.

However, it is important to establish, that transport disadvantage and transport-related social exclusion are not *necessarily* synonymous with each other, i.e. it is possible to be socially excluded but still have good access to transport or to be transport disadvantaged but highly socially included (Currie and Delbosc, 2010). Rather transport disadvantage and social disadvantage interact directly and indirectly to cause transport poverty. This in turn leads to inaccessibility to essential goods and services, as well as 'lock-out' from planning and decision-making processes, which can result in social exclusion outcomes and further social and transport inequalities will then ensue. Fig. 1 is an attempt to illustrate some of these key interactions.

Transport surveys demonstrate that it is most usually the poorest and most socially disadvantaged within society who also experience transport disadvantage. Almost every National Travel Survey (NTS) identifies significant inequalities in the travel patterns and access to transport of lower income populations in comparison to their higher income counterparts. For example, the 2006 UK NTS identifies that, whilst on average car ownership levels rest at around 85%, less than 50% of the lowest income quintile households own a car. Although 40% of individuals in the lowest income households report travelling by car at least once a week, they make only around one-tenth the car trips of members of one car households and they make far fewer trips in a week overall, using any mode of transport (Department for Transport, 2007). The annual journey distances of non-car owners is also roughly half that of car owners (*ibid*) with the consequence that many people on low incomes also experience social exclusion as a direct or partial result of these transport inequalities (Social Exclusion Unit, 2003).

Surprisingly, given the levels of car penetration in the US (approximately 92% of all households have access to a private vehicle), car ownership amongst the lowest income quintile is only slightly higher than it is in the UK (around 60%). Women are more likely to drive across all age categories in the USA than in

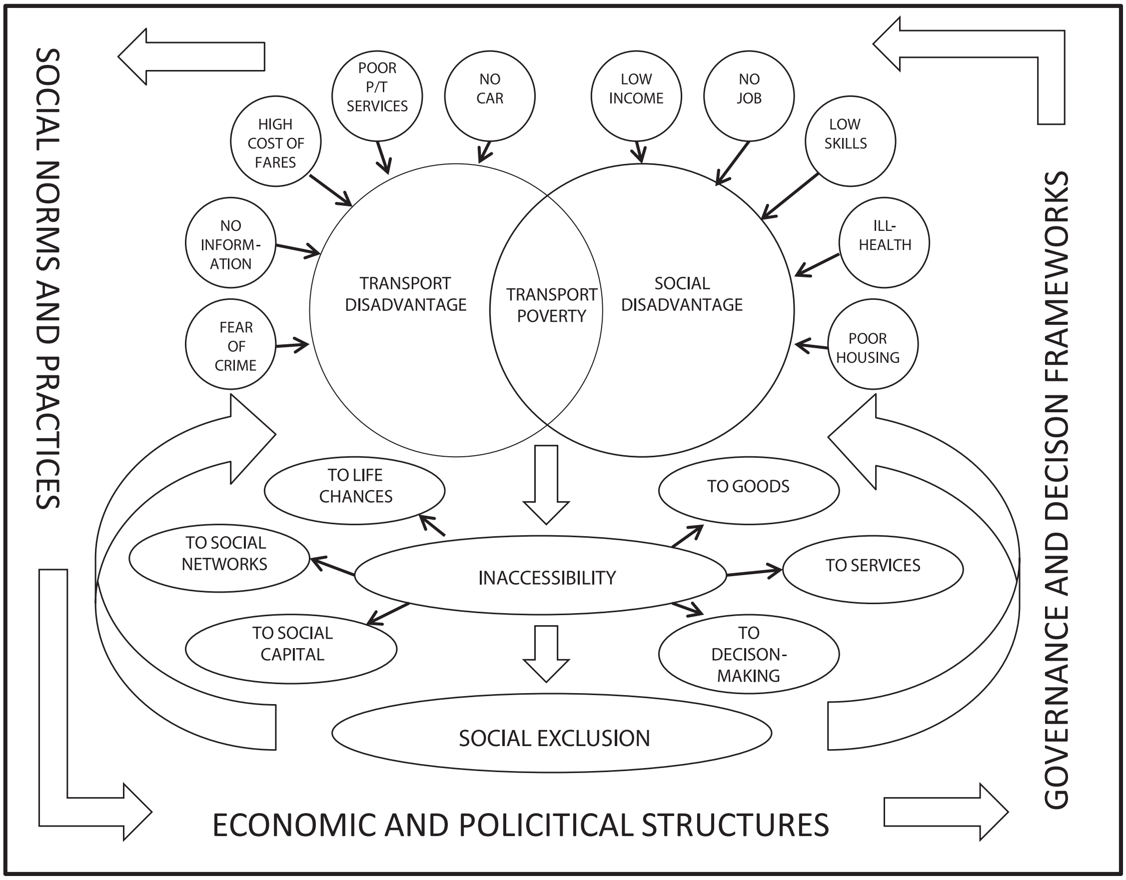

Fig. 1. Diagram to illustrate the relationship between transport disadvantage, social disadvantage and social exclusion.

the UK and there is less of a gender difference between licence holders and non-licence holders than in the UK. Black Americans are far less likely to own and drive a car than their white counterparts, with 20% of all Black households not having access to a car. American Indians, Hispanics, Pacific Islander, Asian and people of mixed race are also less likely to own cars than white Americans (Clifton and Lucas, 2004). There is considerable evidence to suggest that low income non-car owning households in the US also have less access to public transit (Garcia and Rubin, 2004) and, hence, experience considerable difficulties in accessing jobs (Cervero, 2004) and other key facilities (Morris, 2004).

In Australia, Currie et al. (2007) have identified that acute cases of transport tend to be found in suburban and regional areas, where distance is a major barrier to economic and social inclusion. Although, Australia has amongst the highest car ownership in the world, not everyone has a car or can drive. Young people (Johnson, 2011), low income households (Hurni, 2006) and aboriginal populations (Altman and Hinkson, 2007), in particular, are known to experience difficulties in accessing work, education, shops and leisure and cultural activities. Driving cessation is a major concern for older Australians, since economic and social life tends to revolve around the car and cessation has been associated with a decline in travel and social activity in later life (Browning et al., 2007).

In the Canadian context, Páez et al. (2009) (2009b) have been recording similar trends from their analysis of the Toronto and Montreal Household Travel Surveys finding that lower income households and particularly elderly and disabled Canadians travel considerably less and over shorter distances and have less access to key services than the average Canadian population.

These transport inequalities can also be seen within the development context. For example, the 2003 South African National Household Travel Survey identified that identifies that the majority of poorer households also experience extremely poor access to private vehicles and public transport services. On average, only 26% of the lowest income quintile households had access to a car, more than 75% had no access to a train station and nearly 40% did not have access to a bus service. Whilst the majority of the white population (83%) hold a driving licence, only 10% of the black population, and 21% of coloureds[1] and just over half of the Asian population (56%) do so (Republic of South Africa National Household Travel Survey, 2005). As a result, the majority of black South Africans state difficulties when trying to access work, education, healthcare, social welfare assistance and with visiting family members (Lucas, 2011a).

What is less clear from this statistical evidence is the extent to which this reduced mobility and access to services leads to the social exclusion of affected individuals and/or reduces their social capital, life chances and overall well-being. In my view, there have been three key areas of progress in terms of the research of transport and social exclusion which have emerged over the last eight years in this respect: (i) better conceptualisation of transport-related exclusion as a social phenomenon; (ii) improved identification and measurement of social disadvantage and its interaction with transport provision, in different geographical contexts, using new and innovative techniques and; (iii) greater policy recognition of these issues and practical responses to the problem. Given the epic proportions of the task, I only attempt to

[1] Coloured is still an official racial classification within the RSA NHTS

briefly describe progress in each of these areas within the context of this paper (a greater discussion of these issues can be found in Lucas 2011b, 2011 and Lucas and Currie, 2011).

4. Progress with theoretical conceptualisations

Kenyon et al. (2003: 210) offered the following, widely-cited definition of transport-related social exclusion, highlighting its accessibility and mobility dimensions:

> '[It is] The process by which people are prevented from participating in the economic, political and social life of the community because of reduced accessibility to opportunities, services and social networks, due in whole or part to insufficient mobility in a society and environment built around the assumption of high mobility'

This definition is particularly cogent in the transport context because it identifies the relational nature of the problem, i.e. that it is the high and increasing levels of mobility within the population as a whole that is a key causal factor in the reduced, accessibility and, ultimately, exclusion of less mobile sectors of the population.

More specifically, Church et al. (2000: 198–200) denote seven specific features of the transport system that are contributing and/or related to the exclusion of certain population groups, which in line with social exclusion theory would appear to confirm the multidimensional nature of the problem. The identified seven categories are:

i) *physical exclusion*: whereby physical barriers, such as vehicle design, lack of disabled facilities or lack of timetable information, inhibit the accessibility of transport services;
ii) *geographical exclusion*: where a person lives can prevent them from accessing transport services, such as in rural areas or on peripheral urban estates;
iii) *exclusion from facilities*: the distance of key facilities such as shops, schools, health care or leisure services from where a person lives prevents their access;
iv) *economic exclusion*: the high monetary costs of travel can prevent or limit access to facilities or employment and thus impact on incomes;
v) *time-based exclusion:* other demands on time, such as combined work, household and child-care duties, reduces the time available for travel (often referred to as time-poverty in the literature);
vi) *fear-based exclusion:* where fears for personal safety preclude the use of public spaces and/or transport services;
vii) *space exclusion:* where security or space management prevent certain groups access to public spaces, e.g. gated communities or first class waiting rooms at stations.

Whilst this list maps the overall nature of the problem of transport-related exclusion, it does little to express at which level or layer of activity it occurs and, thereby, fails to identify where the policy attention should be directed, i.e. is it the individual which needs direct policy assistance, the social capital of the community that needs to be enhanced or better local services that are needed or the more strategic system of transport or land use planning that needs to be addressed?

4.1. Accessibility perspectives

To address this shortfall, Greico (2006) proposes three main dimensions for the analysis of transport-related social exclusion, namely: (i) place-based measures, including opportunities and services within the immediate area in which a person lives; (ii) social-category based measures, such as social stratification within as community to identify social need; and (iii) person-based measures, such as the individual public transport user's profile of journey needs. However, it is also essential to recognise, the dynamic and relational nature of the exclusionary process where transport is concerned, however, i.e. the more mobile society becomes the more certain groups are excluded from and/or disproportionately impacted by the system (Kenyon, 2003). This suggests that to reduce transport-related social exclusion policy makers should not only be concentrating on the populations that are currently excluded or at risk of exclusion but also on reducing the escalating dynamic of *hypermobility* and its effects across society as a whole (Urry, 2000).

4.2. Social capital and capability perspectives

Urry (2000) builds on this theme of dynamic exclusion from the transport system within his *new mobilities paradigm*. His theories are concerned with macro (global), meso (national) and micro (local) changes in the physical and virtual movement of people, goods, services, images and information over time (Kaufmann, et al., 2004; Sheller and Urry, 2006; Urry, 2007). As Cass et al., 2005 identify, the new mobilities perspective is particularly important because it explores how different forms of mobility help to shape *wider societal values and norms and to reinforce existing social stratification*. Theorists from this perspective identify *motility* (the potential and ability to move) consists of three main layers: (i) *access*—the range of all available mobilities according to time, place and other contextual constraints; (ii) *competence*—the skills and abilities that directly or indirectly relate to the appropriation of access; (iii) *appropriation*—how individuals, groups, networks or institutions act upon or interpret perceived or real access and competences (Kaufmann et al., 2004). Unequal mobilities are seen as arising from differences in the status, wealth, prestige, power and geographical distribution of people and activities (Urry, 2007).

Urry argues that unequal 'network capital' is distributed across traditional social stratifications leading to differential opportunities to access goods, services, social networks and life chances, which results in the social exclusion of both individuals and whole communities. One of the key issues that Urry and his colleagues bring to light within their thesis is the extent to which transport-related social exclusion can ever be properly addressed within a global system that prioritises *hypermobility*. Dennis and Urry (2009) predict it is not until *After the Car* that we will be able to establish the more equitable distribution of transport services. This implies that the problem of transport-related exclusion largely lies outside the influence of national or local policy makers.

4.3. Time geography perspectives

Time geographers have also opened up further challenges for the study of transport-related disadvantage, in particular their consideration of the issue from a time-space perspective,. Theorists here focus on the fundamental societal changes that have taken place over the last fifty years in spatial organisation of society (e.g. Miller 1999; Dijst et al., 2005; Neutens et al., 2009). These structural changes have created new inequalities in the opportunities that are available to different people within given timeframes, causing time-poverty based exclusion for certain social groups, particularly working women with children (Priya Uteng, 2009; Schwanen, 2011). The demands of tight scheduling, multi-tasking and multiple responsibilities are experienced differently by different population groups and by people living in different locations, particularly people living in rural areas and on peripheral urban estates (Lucas, 2004).

The particular insight time geography offers to the analysis of transport-related exclusion is that often it is people's own preferences, needs and attitudes which determine the transport choices that are available to them. In this case, the transport disadvantages or time poverty that they experience may be the product of self-enforced, rather than externally imposed, physical isolation and exclusion (Currie and Delbosc, 2010). Barry (2002) refers to this form of self-imposed exclusion in his chapter entitled 'Social Exclusion, Isolation and Income', finding that:

> 'The private car is the enemy of social solidarity in as much as public transport is its friend. The private car isolates people and puts them in competition with other road users' (Barry, 2002: 26)

He suggests that the problem of higher income sectors of the population effectively 'opting out' from the use of public services is all part of the dynamic nature of the problem of social exclusion and also needs to be addressed by policy.

5. Progress with identification and measurement

As identified above, considerable progress has also been made with the development and application of innovative methods and techniques for the identification and measurement of transport-related social exclusion. These studies have taken place in different geographical and national context and have helped to establish that the phenomenon is universally experienced in both the developed and developing world. They also demonstrate its incidence to be highly correlated with social disadvantage and the level of transport provision that is available within households and neighbourhoods. There are also strong interactions with service delivery patterns, housing density and land uses, as well as the structure of the local economy and employment patterns.

It is not possible to revisit all of these studies in the context of this paper, but the examples which have been selected aim offer a flavour of the range of different methodological approaches which have been applied.

5.1. Accessibility studies in the uk

Since the publication of the SEU report in 2003 there have been numerous academic studies which have explored the various issues of mobility, accessibility and transport disadvantage in different geographical contexts in the UK. The main contribution of these studies has been to identify the highly context- and person-specific nature of transport-related exclusion, which clearly not only differs in terms of the experiences of low-income rural and urban populations (e.g. McDonagh, 2006; Farrington, 2007, Wright et al., 2009), but has also been demonstrated to vary for different socially excluded population groups within the same local contexts (e.g. Rajé, 2004; Preston and Raje, 2007; Mackett et al., 2006; Jones and Wixey, 2008). In most instances these studies have involved detailed local accessibility mapping of local travel survey data in combination with the transport system, using enhanced GIS-based tools.

For example, a Scottish study, Hine and Mitchell (2003) focused on three geographically defined case study areas to identify ways in which the transport system was creating transport disadvantage and to establish how this might be addressed through policy. The surveys identified that the residents who relied solely on public transport found it more difficult to access key activities in the local area and a small number of respondents in each of the three areas reported that transport considerations had prevented them from looking for work or accepting a job and/or accessing education. Respondents without a car also tended to go less frequently on shopping trips and to visit friends and family. Respondents also expressed a high degree of concern for their personal safety in relation to accessing and using public transport.

However, Preston and Raje (2007) identified that having transport (whether private or transit) available is not always a factor in social exclusion and that it is only where the price of transport exceeds its affordability that social exclusion occurs. On this basis, they recommend that policy maker can improve social inclusion by either; reducing the price of transport, and/or increasing social contact through virtual mobility, and/or increasing proximate facilities/contacts through land-use planning or pro-neighbourhood policies, and/or increasing incomes. Using a GIS-based mapping tool of the local walking environment and data collected through footfall surveys, Mackett et al. (2008) demonstrated the importance of micro level infrastructure for some disadvantaged groups.

5.2. Spatial and social network analysis in mainland Europe

Ohnmacht et al. (2009) identify three European studies to identify the interaction between people's spatial networks and the social inequalities which can arise from an increasing demand for people to be more mobile. The first of these summarised the key findings of the GLOBALLIFE project, which was designed to perform a cross-national comparison empirical analysis of the effects of globalisation processes on the life-courses of men and women (Blossfeld et al., 2009). The study concludes that the spatial dynamics of the globalisation process have significantly affected the mobility of labour and labour capital. This has had the effect of reinforcing pre-existing social inequalities and class divides.

In the second case study, Frei et al. (2009) argue that an individual's social networks are a particularly important area of study for social exclusion, in that they are generally seen to be the main way in which individuals and communities maintain their social capital. The stronger the social network, the greater the level of social capital and thereby access to life opportunities and resources. The study identified that car ownership (and the associated mobility that this offers) had a positive effect on the size and strength of the respondents' social networks. Being less anchored to a physical location and also more professionally flexible also had a positive effect on the size of a person's social network.

Furthering in this theme of social capital, the third case study considered the relationship between social capital and commuting in the Swiss cities of Zurich, Genoa and Basle (Viry et al., 2009). The authors found that having 'a strong mobility capital' allows individuals to maintain or widen their social capital. Conversely, for the disadvantaged populations in the samples (particularly for isolated women with children, migrants, less educated people and people with disabilities) having no car and living in a place isolated from the public transport system, effectively acts to weaken their social capital.

In a Norwegian study, Priya Uteng (2009) used a combination of quantitative and qualitative methods to understand the mobility patterns and transport-related exclusion of a specific sector of the Norwegian population, namely non-Western female immigrants, who have been identified as particularly isolated from mainstream economic and social participation in Norwegian society. Importantly, her study identifies the way in which ethnically divided space shapes a sense of both belonging and difference, including language, codes of behaviour, value systems and social networks, which have little or nothing to do with either transport or spatial planning. She argues that in this context, mobility (and ergo transport) becomes a highly internalised personal confine, which serves to act against integration. From a methodological point of view, therefore, place-based measures of accessibility ignores these highly individualised (and internally imposed) experiences of social exclusion, which also predominantly lay outside of the transport policy makers' jurisdiction to address.

5.3. Structural and spatial modelling studies in Australia and Canada

Currie et al. (2009, 2010) undertook structural equation modelling of data from the Victoria Household Travel Survey to empirically measure the links between transport disadvantage (on a number of different self-reported dimensions); social exclusion (using pre-determined indicators of income, unemployment, political engagement, participation and social support) and well-being (using an internationally recognised Satisfaction with Life Scale). Their modelled results showed the positive relationship between transport and disadvantage to be highly statistically significant ($p < .001$). Interestingly, however, the authors found no significant relationship between realised trips and self-reported experiences of transport disadvantage, i.e. people who travelled a lot were just as likely to report difficulties with their transport as those who travelled little. It was identified that this was largely due to a time-poverty issue with the higher income, economically active respondents, which seems to support Barry's thesis above (2002) that less disadvantaged people may also experience social exclusion from the physical isolation that a car based society allows. Currie and Stanley (2006) have also explored the role of public transport in promoting social capital in the Australian context, suggesting the links to be small but nevertheless significant, particularly for older sectors of the population.

In Canada, Páez et al. (2009, 2010) also modelled the prevalence and extent of transport-related social exclusion in Toronto and Montreal using Household Travel Survey data, Census and Business Point Data. Their study focused on three vulnerable groups; seniors, low income people and single parent households within the urban areas of Hamilton, Toronto, and Montreal. Their analysis was based on a statistical and spatial modelling approach to identify person- and location-specific estimates of trip making frequency and distance travelled. They identified car ownership as highly important in influencing both trip generation and distance travelled, except in the case of single parent households. They concluded that, in general, the three identified vulnerable groups tend to make fewer or no trips, and have smaller activity spaces than the average population in both study areas. In terms of their three accessibility case studies, in Toronto, single parent households have relatively better accessibility to jobs near the central part of the city, but experience relative accessibility deprivation outside of this area. In Montreal, they found that low income individuals' access to retail food tends to be relatively better than access to fast food in the central part of the region and the outer suburbs, but the opposite is true of a broad ring covering the outer part of the central city and the inner suburbs. Finally, in Hamilton, access to health care services for senior citizens was also relatively higher in the central part of the city but tends to decay very rapidly outside of this area, resulting in extremely low accessibility in most parts of the city.

There is clearly some way to go in terms of establishing systematic robust and effective ways to identify the extent and severity of transport-related social exclusion in different contexts and for different sectors of the population. Nevertheless, these studies demonstrate significant progress in this respect since 2003. The question remains as to how far these studies have had an impact on policy and service delivery in practice and is the focus of the next section of this paper.

6. Progress in policy and with practical delivery

Despite its limited scope, the paper thus far has established that transport-related social exclusion is broadly accepted as a broad-brush theoretical concept for describing the social consequences of transport disadvantage within the academic literature. I next consider the extent to which this has influenced the transport policy agenda and/or been realised in the practical deliver of new transport projects at the local level. I draw specifically upon the two examples with which I am personally familiar: UK and Australia. Progress is not limited to these national contexts, however, and government websites reveal that policy makers in France, Spain, Canada, New Zealand, and South Africa are all currently responding to the transport and social exclusion agenda. Although often not specifically using the language of social exclusion, many other countries, such as the United States, Germany and the Netherlands, also offer policies to address the transport needs of socially disadvantaged population groups. This would suggest a break from transport policy tradition, which has in the past tended towards a greater recognition of the economic and environmental outcomes of planning and decision-making.

6.1. The UK experience

The Social Exclusion Unit (SEU) study of transport and social exclusion is widely recognised as having an important influence on the UK policy approach (Social Exclusion Unit, 2003). Most importantly it introduced a systematic process of *accessibility planning* within local transport, land use and service sector planning to identify and address the transport problems of socially excluded populations. Since 2006, there is a statutory requirement for local transport authorities to undertake strategic and local accessibility assessments as part of their five year Local Transport Plans. They must work in partnership with other local public bodies and key stakeholders to find solutions to the accessibility deficits these analyses identify (Department for Transport, 2006).

In 2009, the Department for Transport commissioned a three-year evaluation study to identify both the progress and impact of accessibility planning within local transport authorities. This has not yet officially reported and so, as yet, there are no formal evaluations of accessibility planning or of the interventions that have been put in place. An interim report (Centre for the Research of Social Policy (CRSP), 2009) identified major differences in approaches across the nine case studies it examined. It found that some authorities were targeting improved access at socially excluded groups and others introducing more universal measures for improved accessibility for all. Some plans were more transport-sector focused whilst other shared the responsibility for improvements with other key stakeholders such as health providers or social services. The research identified the important role of local champions as crucial to the delivery process; the authorities who had key personnel who understood both the value of the process and have the skills to develop multi-stakeholder agreement are making the biggest impact on the ground. Some local transport authorities have also achieved notable success with engaging other sectors in accessibility planning process. For example, both Merseytravel (Merseyside) and Centro (West Midlands) have secured significant partnership collaborations with their local employment services through the Workwise programme, which provides assistance with travel in the transition from welfare into work.

Other evaluation research has identified that public transport improvements in deprived areas have delivered significant improvements in bus patronage and travel uptake, as well as having knock-on benefits in terms of the take-up of new employment, educational opportunities and healthcare visits (Lucas et al., 2008; Bristow et al., 2008). However, it has been virtually impossible to maintain the introduction of such initiatives with the advent of new economic austerity measures in the UK. Much of the subsidy funding for these new services has now run out and most are unable to continue to operate on a commercial (non-subsidy) basis. In addition, local transport authorities are reviewing their provision of socially necessary bus services more generally in light of major cutbacks in central government funding streams.

The 'new localism' agenda which is currently being propounded by the Coalition Government would suggest a tendency towards greater locally determined projects, with a potential danger that communities with the greatest political leverage will benefit whilst those with less capacity lose out. Meanwhile, both the Social Exclusion Unit and the Mobility and Inclusion Unit have been disbanded within central government and the focus of the social policy agenda for transport under the new administration remains opaque. These trends obviously have considerable implications for the future of the transport and social exclusion policy at both the national and local level.

6.2. *The Australian policy experience (State of Victoria)*

Whilst the transport and social exclusion agenda appears to be on the wane in the UK, in the Australian context the reverse appears to be true, although it has followed quite a different policy trajectory here. In Australia, the federal government devolves most of the functions of transport governance to its States, which are responsible for autonomous policy development and delivery. This means that transport policy-making and planning is much more regionally diverse and it is not possible to generalise the transport agenda across States. For this reason, I will focus on policy and delivery progress in the State of Victoria only. Since 2008, the Victoria Department of Transport (VICDOT) has been a lead player in the development of a transport and social exclusion agenda along similar lines to the SEU approach. Although other States have been developing their own social transport agendas, VICDOT is generally recognised as the front runner in this respect.

Transport disadvantage had long been recognised as a policy problem at the national level within Australia (e.g. Travers Morgan, 1992), but States were slow to adopt appropriate implementation strategies. For example, in the State of Victoria the process only began in 2004, when a group of transport academics and policy makers in the Melbourne region came together to discuss the issue of transport-related social exclusion in the Australian context, largely motivated by the SEU study. An edited publication resulted from the collaboration, which helped to establish an evidence base for transport-related social exclusion for certain population sectors and areas in Australia (Currie et al., 2007). A local organising committee was formed called the 'Transport and Social Inclusion Committee' (TASIC) which held a series of seminars and conferences to campaign for government action on policy to improve social inclusion outcomes from a transport perspective (Monash University, 2007).

The Victorian State Government had already campaigned on a platform that sought to address social disadvantage and studies have been undertaken by other independent agencies to comprehensively identify key areas of deprivation across urban and rural Melbourne (e.g. Vinson, 2004). Its policy platform 'A Fairer Victoria' (Victoria Department of the Premier and Cabinet, 2005a, 2005b) focused on social sustainability and sought to improve access to services, reduce barriers to opportunity, strengthen assistance for disadvantaged groups and places and ensure that people get the help they need. Transport policies were briefly noted in this social policy document but were largely absent from the delivery plans of this and subsequent social policy documents.

Specific approaches to addressing transport disadvantage are described in various Department of Infrastructure documents (State of Victoria, 2008a, 2008b). Up to 2007 the main aim of the Victorian programme had been to reduce this transport disadvantaged through funded increases in public transport service levels with a focus on fringe urban and rural contexts (Loader and Stanley, 2009). In addition, the level of fares had been reduced for certain disadvantaged key groups (seniors over 60 years, young people under 18 years, people with disabilities and jobseekers) on a State wide basis. These measures directly targeted transport-related social exclusion related to transport and were part of what is termed 'social transit' within Victorian policy. This refers to transport services, including fixed route bus services, which cater for sections of the community that have limited or no transport options (Betts, 2007). It is separate from transport service catering for 'mass transit' i.e. volume not needs.

The Transport Connections Programme (TCP) has been another key feature of the Victorian approach (Victoria Department of Planning and Community Development website). This sought to build the capabilities of local government to find innovative solutions to transport disadvantage. It provided the financial support to employ local transport coordinators within communities in order to build partnerships to deliver services between councils, local community transport providers and the resident community itself. A key theme is enduring outcomes and support for coordination of resources. An AU$4.19 m (approx. £2.9 m) 'flexible fund' supports the programme by providing funding for new projects. This programme is also seeking to find localised ways to bridge gaps due to 'silo thinking' between agencies and providers of transit. Since 2010, VICDOT has also established a Social Transit Unit to work closely across the department and its wider transport portfolio and with other government agencies and the community sector to identify issues that prevent people using the public transport system.

Loader and Stanley (2009) have identified that the *Smartbus*' programme of improved 'social transit' services in Outer Melbourne that were supported through the 'flexible transport fund' has resulted in both patronage growth and social inclusion. Services have been upgraded to offer new minimum service levels, particularly extending the duration and frequency and operating hours of services and re-routing services to link with key employment, education and shopping destinations in the urban periphery. All five new routes have experienced significant patronage growth exceeding the relative growth that would have been expected from the introduction of traditionally routed peak services within central Melbourne. They have also opened up new employment and social opportunities and have increased social capital and inclusion, particularly for the youth and elderly population.

The federal government in Canberra is now also looking into the development of guidelines for addressing transport-related social exclusion at the national level.

7. Conclusions: where are we now?

This paper offers a flavour of the theoretical, empirical and policy progress that has been made in the field of transport and social exclusion since 2003, which has been identified as a pivotal point in this agenda. It has established that the concepts of social exclusion and its theories and methodologies emerged from the social policy discipline in the mid-1990s and were later pick-up on and explored as an area of related interest by transport researchers. One key question, therefore, is whether the concept has travelled well and whether it has been recognised and accepted as a discrete and robust subject area within the discipline.

It is clear from even the partial and limited coverage of the paper that since the relatively recent appearance of transport and social exclusion in the early 2000, progress has been considerable on three fronts. Firstly, the paper has established that the concept of transport-related social exclusion now has significant resonance with the transport research and policy community internationally. Secondly, it has shown that the methodologies that have been developed and applied to identify and measure transport-related exclusion as a social phenomenon are highly varied, innovative and increasingly sophisticated in their overall design. Thirdly, the findings of the studies that have been undertaken add considerable weight to the claim that transport-related exclusion can be identified as a universal and operational concept, although it is differentially experienced within and between nations and by different social groups in different social and geographical contexts.

Despite this research progress and a promising early start in the UK, there appears to be relatively poor take-up of the transport and social exclusion agenda amongst local transport authorities. The VICDOT case is perhaps the exception to this rule, although even here the effort is meagre in comparison to the overall public transport spend for the region and it is still early days. Part of the problem has been with articulation and communication of the agenda to key delivery agencies, as well as a lack of available public subsidy for promoting new 'social transit' services more generally. There is a general consensus amongst those with an interest in seeing this agenda more widely promoted that better social evaluation and appraisal tools are needed at every level of governance. Metrics are needed to establish the minimum level and standards of public transport which are necessary for social inclusion given certain distances, densities, levels of services, etc. and local targets set to achieve these within given timeframes. To achieve this goal, social inclusion also has to be an explicitly stated outcome within service contracts with public transport operators.

Neither should the transport and social exclusion agenda be limited to a local or even national governance agenda, but should also be extended to high level funders of major infrastructure programmes such as the World Bank and other Development Banks. Indeed, it is arguably even more important to meet such basic standards of transport inclusion in the Global South, where the majority of the population is faced by woefully inadequate transport services and the social exclusion which results from a basic lack of access to employment, education, healthcare and other basic amenities.

What is clear from the case studies that are already available is that there is no panacea for addressing the problem of transport-related exclusion. One size definitely does not fit all and so many more examples are needed of what does and does not work in practice, within different geographical and social contexts and for different groups of people. If properly designed and delivered, public transport can provide a part of this solution, but it is most likely that other forms of more flexible (and often informal) transport services will be needed to complement these mainstream services. This does not come cheap and, as the UK experience demonstrates, if not properly supported and subsidised, these complementary measures will not deliver their desired outcomes.

Furthermore, transport and social exclusion can never survive as a solely transport-focused agenda. The accessibility planning (in its broadest sense) of public transport which is necessary to meet the travel needs of socially excluded people must be highly integrated with socially responsible land use, housing, health, education and welfare policies and programmes. Similarly, large transport infrastructure projects need to be more transparent in their ex ante analyses to consider their long-term social equity effects on local populations and communities.

It is my belief that much progress has already been made within the transport sector to recognise and begin to address the issues raised by this paper, but as yet we still have a long way to go in convincing other key sectors of the value of recognising the importance of this agenda. This will only happen if we are willing and able to raise the profile of our research within other relevant policy sectors such as health, social policy, development studies and housing and planning. We need to convince our colleagues in these other policy areas that transport really matters to them and their own policy goals.

Finally, we need to recognise that the social research agenda itself is moving forward. In light of the current global economic crisis, many researchers in geography, urban studies and elsewhere are now fundamentally questioning the neo-liberal agenda and the theories and concepts which have supported it. Issues of social, spatial and environmental justice are brought to the fore within their emerging research debates, which suggest that wholly new, radical and transformative research programmes are needed in order to overthrow the redundant social development paradigms of a bygone era. To meet this challenge we need to develop new interdisciplinary theories and innovative methodological approaches so that policymakers can move beyond the ineffective 'trickle-down' models they are currently applying and towards the development of 'just cities' for all. Transport and access has a fundamental role to play in this transition and so understanding the processes, actions and decisions which lead to transport-related exclusion should be one of the key foci of our future transport policy research.

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